the 800 seats already sanctioned for eight new medical colleges that were to begin classes in the next academic year. Better-performing states/ UTs outside the south—Goa, Himachal Pradesh, Manipur, Sikkim, the Andaman & Nicobar Islands, Chandigarh, Puducherry et al—too will share this anomalous plight of actually being prohibited from making more provisions for medical education just because they have already demonstrated their capacity to do so.

On the other end of the spectrum lies Uttar Pradesh, with its estimated 235 million population. The existing 9,703 seats in its medical colleges only add up to a ratio of about 41 to a million, and it can add about 13,800 seats to reach the mandated figure of 100. The NMC's reasoning is that allowing gaps like those to be filled will "reduce regional disparities in the availability of healthcare professionals". It also offers the rationale of preventing "overcrowding" at medical colleges. How long it might take the laggard states to make up the deficit isn't part of the equation.

As of June 2022, 1.3 million doctors were registered with the NMC. Going by Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) population projections, there is a doctor for every 1,060 individuals in 2023, close to the World Health Organization's prescribed doctor-to-population ratio of 1: 1,000. But the distribution remains skewed in favour of developed states nationally and in urban areas within states. For instance, the ministry of health and family welfare's Rural Health Statistics show that 21.8 per cent of India's public health centres and sub-centres had no doctors in 2021. This, even as the number of MBBS seats went up from 51,348 in 2014 to 107,000 in 2021—a compound annual growth rate of 11 per cent.

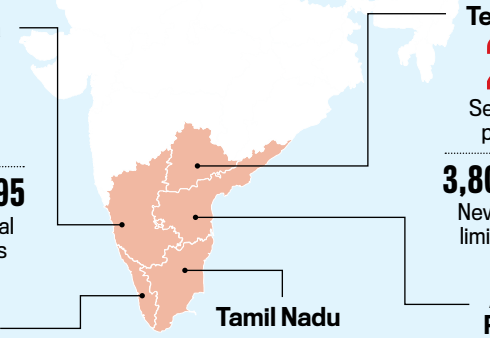
The NMC move feeds the sentiment gaining ground in the south that they are being penalised for offering better education and health facilities in comparison to the north. That's what the Tamil Nadu CM contends in his letter to Modi. Stalin argues that states like Tamil Nadu have achieved a higher doctor-to-population ratio primarily through investments made by state governments and the private sector, not the Centre. But though the state's overall numbers are adequate, Stalin reasons, there are districts that are still lagging. "Any restriction on new medical colleges based on a state-level criterion will deprive these deserving districts of the much-needed tertiary institutions," he wrote.

Stalin has cited a 2022 Supreme Court judgment, which affirmed that executive instructions should not impose unreasonable restrictions on the fundamental right to establish educational institutions. Stating that the NMC notification may thus be legally untenable, he has sought its suspension besides urging Modi to initiate a consultative process between the MoHFW and the states on the issue.

This is a fresh flashpoint between the Centre and peninsular states amid a larger vexatious issue—the population-based delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies, scheduled for after 2026, which could see southern states lose their strength in Parliament. Congress MP Shashi Tharoor has called for a "new southern consciousness" in the face of this impending exercise. "The south has brought its population growth down to almost replacement levels," he recently said, "and it fears to be politically disenfranchised in the face of the galloping numbers in the north." With leaders across the spectrum raising similar apprehensions, the NMC notification is likely to face stiff resistance in days to come. ■

WHAT'S THE ROW

A National Medical Commission notification has limited the number of MBBS seats in any state/ UT to 100 per one million population



Karnataka
173 Seats/ million population
6,760 New limit | 11,695 Actual seats

Telangana
225 Seats/ million population
3,800 New limit | 8,540 Actual Seats

Kerala
130 Seats/ million population
3,570 New limit | 4,655 Actual seats

Tamil Nadu
151 Seats/ million population
7,680 New limit | 11,600 Actual seats

Andhra Pradesh
121 Seats/ million Population
5,340 New limit | 6,435 Actual seats

- NMC reasons that using the population criterion for MBBS seats will "reduce regional disparities" and prevent overcrowding at medical colleges
- All southern states have already exceeded the new limit, preventing them from opening new medical colleges or adding more MBBS seats in existing ones
- It is feeding the sentiment gaining ground in the South that they are being penalised for offering better education and health facilities in comparison to the "laggard" North

Source: NMC; population projections by UIDAI